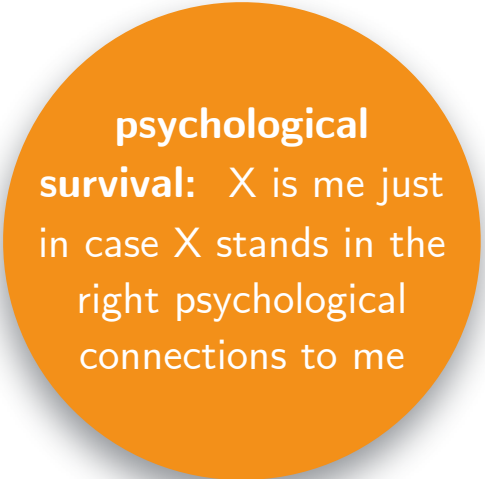


Is life after
death
possible?

Matters are less clear when it comes to our other answers
to the survival question.

A large orange circle with a soft drop shadow, containing white text.

psychological
survival: X is me just
in case X stands in the
right psychological
connections to me

soul survival:

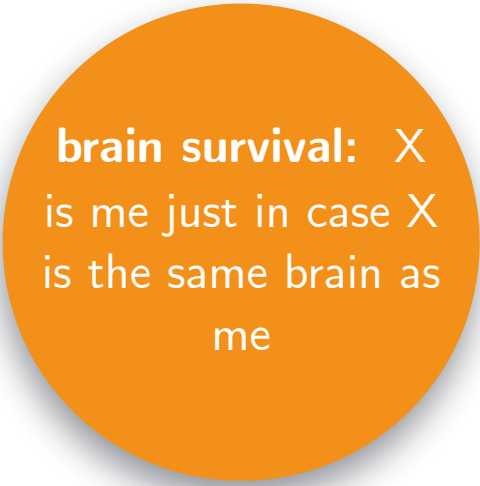
X is me just in case
X is the same
immaterial soul as
me

organism

survival: X is me
just in case X is the
same organism as
me

combination

survival: X is me
just in case X is the
combination of my
soul and my body

A large orange circle with a soft drop shadow, centered on a white background. Inside the circle is white text.

brain survival: X
is me just in case X
is the same brain as
me

These views differ in important ways, but they all agree that your survival depends on the survival of a certain physical thing.

Views of this kind face an obvious problem in making sense of the possibility of life after death. After death bodies decay (or are cremated). Doesn't that just show that the relevant physical objects won't survive your death — and so that, if one of the above views is right, you won't?

This is a problem which has long troubled philosophers in
the Christian tradition.

This might sound surprising. After all, don't Christians believe that one's immaterial soul is enough for life after death?

In fact, this is not the traditional Christian view. The following quote from Aquinas is representative:

“The necessity of holding the resurrection arises from this — that man may obtain the last end for which he was made. This cannot be accomplished in this life, nor in the life of the separated soul ... it is necessary for the selfsame man to rise again; and this is effected by the selfsame soul being united to the selfsame body. For otherwise there would be no resurrection properly speaking, if the same man were not reformed.”

This is also implied by the use of the word “resurrection”
— if life after death were simply the continued existence
of an immaterial soul, then there would be nothing
needing to be “raised up.”

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